successor to the then chief of army staff as I was not only going to be the seniormost at that time but also equally good, if not more meritorious, as compared to other competitors. Although it was never a consideration as far as I was concerned, some people were speculating whether or not the government would appoint a Sikh officer as the army chief. If it did so, it would be the first instance in the history of independent India of a Sikh leading a 1.3-million-strong Indian Army. Setting aside all speculation, the government decided to do precisely that. The greatest chapter of my life was about to begin.



Laying a wreath at Amar Jawan Jyoti, India Gate, New Delhi, 1 February 2005.